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In a digital world, what do you expect of cameras but that they'll be digital? Sure, you have fans of analogue—as in audio equipment, and yes, even with cameras, as in film—but they're a dying breed, and you decide whether that's a good thing or a bad thing. Film cams are a fancy, a different art now. They're just not for you if you're a regular guy or girl!

So here's the deal, as usual: we test them, you buy them! Let's get straight on to telling you what we found after evaluating, very critically, the 31 lucky cameras that made it to this test.

Categories: A Matter Of Price

We only tested point-and-shoot cameras, so the most obvious categorisation is one based on price. First, we set the upper ceiling for this test as Rs 25,000. Second, we set Rs 8,000 as the ceiling for the entry-level cameras. With that in mind, we came up with three categories.

Cameras retailing at under Rs 8,000 cater to newcomers with no serious photography in mind, and who just want a camera for casual shots now and then. Basically, if you're saying, "I just want a camera; and I don't have any special needs in mind," then this is your category. We're calling this the Simple Shooters category.

The second category has cameras between Rs 8001 and Rs 15,000. This includes the mid-range cameras that have better performance but not necessarily the coolest designs, and we're calling this category "A Cut Above." The final group would be cameras priced between Rs 15,001 and Rs 25,000—"The Cream of the Crop" category. Here you'll find cameras with the most advanced features and performance along with style and elegance in one package.

SIMPLE SHOOTERS (BELOW RS 8,000)

It's mostly TECH-COM here, along with lone contenders from iMedia, Premier, and Mustek.

Design

The TECH-COM cameras have a cheap, plastic feel, but they're light. The buttons are rather clunky, and require some pressure to register a click; the resultant sudden click creates some shake, which often ends up as blur in the photos. Hence one has to be careful and use timer if possible.

The Premier DC6370 is one of the better cameras in terms of design.

Almost every Simple Shooter comes with a pouch and a handle. What you don't get is a charger, which is unfortunate because you'd have to spend anything between Rs 600 and Rs 1200 for a set of rechargeable batteries and a charger.

Features

As you might expect, we saw hardly any advanced features in this category. The features department is where the cams in this category lose out the most when compared

with those in the other categories.

The TECH-COM cameras had pretty much the same set of features across all models.

Performance

In our flash test, the TECH-COM 524X PLUS has a fairly large advantage over the 512X PLUS in terms of clarity and colour contrast. The Mustek and the Premier cameras were behind in this test.

Macro photography was close to impossible in comparatively low light, and this goes for all the cameras in this group.

Accurate focusing is the main issue, followed by long-duration shutter speeds, which is the cause of most of the blur. The TECH-COM 512X PLUS and the iMedia DC-5360S are marginally better than the rest, though.

Outdoor photos, naturally, were much easier to shoot. The colour rendition of the TECH-COM cameras were very similar, but the Mustek MDC530 showed a very light pinkish red instead of a dark red.

In our indoor studio lights test, the Premier DC6370 brought up some very bright fluorescent green in some of the plant photos, and captured the yellow pencil as a pale green, and the orange as... you get the idea.

Value

The prices of the seven Simple Shooters were all within Rs 1,000 of each other. The TECH-COM 601 was quite undoubtedly the worst of the lot, clearly because of the lack of basic functions such as zoom

and focusing... no focus means there isn't even a half-press button: you directly click the photo!

The best overall performance here came from the TECH-COM 524X PLUS, priced just Rs 500 more than the cheapest camera of the lot, the iMedia DC-5360S.

Consider the 524X if you want the cheapest decent-performing camera in this test. If you want to save Rs 150, which will just about buy you a pizza, get the TECH-COM 512X PLUS.

A CUT ABOVE (RS 8,001 TO RS 15,000)

These cameras are most likely what you'd walk out of a store with. We saw some decent performance here, as well as some superior features integrated. This segment comprises of 12 cameras and better-known brands enter the scene.

Design

The design of the Samsung S850 is anything but fancy. The screen is pretty large and pretty crisp as well, even in daylight. The buttons are a little clunky, and the zoom has to be controlled using a little flat notch at the back of the camera, which has to be moved up and down to zoom in and out. This will take some getting used to.

The Canon PowerShot(PS) A450 and PowerShot A460 have the old-fashioned long, blocky design, and might not be the best to carry around in your pocket. The Kodak and



TECH-COM DSC-524X PLUS

Decent camera with no noticeable flaws